

John 15:1-17

True Spirituality: *Abiding In Christ*

Introduction:

Today and next week—I want to address the question of “true spirituality... to refocus and perhaps rediscover what all of this Christianity is all about, perhaps then providing a context to re-evaluate our lives and existence as a church! It’s one of those “lets step back” moments if per chance we have lost the big picture or gotten off message!

Today: True Spirituality as related to ‘Abiding in Christ’

Next week: True Spirituality as related to “The Power of Christ”

Our text both weeks : John 15

Exposition:

I. Context: *His hour had come...*

John 13:1

Now before the festival of the Passover, Jesus knew that his hour had come to depart from this world and go to the Father. Having loved his own who were in the world, he loved them to the end.

13:33, Where I am going, you cannot come.’

Think about this-- What did they hear?

,If to be a disciple of Christ during his earthly ministry meant hanging out with Christ... what does it mean now that he is gone?

Would Christianity forever be in memory of Christ, a political crusade based on his politics, a cause, an ethic based upon his teachings, a special meeting to memorialize his life, a philosophy... what?

E.g. With the loss of the person, whatever else Christianity becomes, it can not longer mean hanging out with the *person* Jesus, we are left with meetings, organizations, codes of ethics, more meetings, pews, committees, buildings tradition, more meetings... and did I say Meetings... **it all makes me want to become a Buddhist!!!**

Buddhism isn’t personal... but neither does it have meetings organizations, laws and codes... just spirituality and so call power that comes from this...Think about it... If modern man imagined a world with out religion a la John Lenin... the post modern person imagines a world with religion, but in the form of a spirituality without forms, organizations, codes—just power wed to a lifestyle of my own making basically... free sex, free spending, free everything with spirituality to back it up

Without Jesus ... the whole think is nauseating! Without the “person” of Jesus, his presence, his being, his values, his PERSON, I’m bored of it all after just 28 plus years— and I think about becoming a neo-Buddhist!

Jesus said, Where I am going, you cannot come.’ So what other option do we have?

In the context of Christ's teaching that he must leave them... he says this...

Abide in me...

e.g. *even though I go to a place you cannot come...*

John 14:18

"I will not leave you orphaned; *I am coming to you.*

John 15:4 *Abide in me as I abide in you...*

Abide? What does this mean?

After doing an extensive word study in the greek, it means "abide" e.g.

stay, remain: continue with/in... stand with, live, endure...

"Stay" to my dog means "don't move from that spot"

"Stay" to a spouse means, don't forsake me, don't leave me—remain in your marriage...

Jesus words "Stay in me" to a Christian means "keep it personal, keep it intimate—continue hanging out with me... don't forsake me the person for some religious counterfeit!

Christianity is still about the God who can be known in the person and work of Christ...so Jesus tells his disciples to abide in him after he is gone...

But how if Christ is where we can't go, much less stay/remain, hang out... ?

Answer: "

1) Abide in Christ by Faith

abide in me and I in you

Is it that "Christ abiding in us is dependent on our abiding in him" even as abiding in him is the same as "keeping his commandments" such as to be saved by good works? NO

Notice... we abide him by keeping his word and "keeping his word" is equated with believing in Christ, albeit as this will also play out in obedience as well...

E.g. Context: his "word" is concerning the works that he does that we are to believe in his words as concerning his person and works¹

Note:

1) 14: 11 "Believe Me that I am in the Father and the Father is in Me (e.g. the "word concerning who Jesus is and what he has come to do);

2) otherwise believe because of the works themselves (e.g. the work of Christ as related to his death and resurrection especially). 12 "Truly, truly, I say to you, he who believes in Me, the works that I do, he will do also; and greater works than these he will do; because I go to the Father.

Abiding in Christ cannot happen apart from faith!

2) Abide in Christ's Love

John 13:34 I give you a new commandment, that you love one another. Just as I have loved you, you also should love one another. 35 By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another.”

John 14:15

“If you love me, you will keep my commandments. 16 And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Advocate, to be with you forever.

So then,

15:9 “Just as the Father has loved Me, I have also loved you; abide in My love. 10 “If you keep My commandments, you will **abide** in My love; just as I have kept My Father’s commandments and abide in His love. 11 “These things I have spoken to you so that My joy may be **in** you, and *that* your joy may be made **full**. 12 “This is My commandment, that you love one another, just as I have loved you. 13 “Greater love has no one than this, that one lay down his life for his friends.

Ephesians

3:17 and that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith, as you are being rooted and grounded in love. 18 I pray that you may have the power to comprehend, with all the saints, what is the breadth and length and height and depth, 19 and to know the love of Christ that surpasses knowledge, so that you may be **filled** with all the fullness of God.

E.g. Through the fellowship of believers in love, we fellowship with Christ... we are made to be “filled with all the fullness of God in our midst in the communion of the saints together in love!

Jesus mediates his fellowship in the fellowship of believers!

Again, Abiding in Christ cannot happen apart from the fellowship of Believers in love!

But is this of our own doing—can we simply “will” to have faith and “will” to have love and leave it to this?

NO!

We still haven’t really answer the question, at least not fully, how is Christ with us if he is in a place we cannot go...

Again:

John 14:18

“I will not leave you orphaned; *I am coming to you.*

John 15:4 ***Abide in me as I abide in you...***

How?

3) Holy Spirit: Christ has come to us in the Holy Spirit that we might abide with Christ

14:17 This is the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees him nor knows him. You know him, because he **abides** with you, and he **will** be **in you**.

John 14:25

“I have said these things to you **while I am still with you**. 26 But the Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, (when he goes to where we can’t go bodily)

I.e. At Pentecost, the coming of the Holy Spirit was nothing less than the advent of Christ in the present age prior to his bodily coming again!

notice especially, Jesus is “abiding” with the disciples in the flesh, but when he leaves, the father sends the HS “in Jesus name” even as Jesus then says “I will come to you (vs.18)

4) The Instruments of the Spirit According to the Apostolic Foundation

What Jesus is promising is nothing short of his continued presence as it will be brought forth through the foundation of the apostles..

Eph. 2:20... built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Jesus himself as the cornerstone. 21 In him the whole structure is joined together and grows into a holy temple in the Lord; 22 in whom you also are built together spiritually into a dwelling place for God.

1Cor. 3:10

According to the grace of God given to me, like a skilled master builder I laid a foundation, and someone else is building on it. Each builder must choose with care how to build on it. 11 For no one can lay any foundation other than the one that has been laid; that foundation is Jesus Christ.

There was an intense period of some 40 years when the spirit of God spoke through the apostles in order to witness to and interpret the death and resurrection of Christ, and to put in place a new context where by we are enabled to “abide in Christ”

1. Words given by HS come through the apostles:

14:26 ...will teach you everything, and remind you of all that I have said to you.

2Pet. 1:19

So we have the prophetic message more fully confirmed. You will do well to be attentive to this as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts. 20 First of all you must understand this, that no prophecy of scripture is a matter of one’s own interpretation, 21 because no prophecy ever came by human will, but men and women moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God.

2. Word in our midst by the sacraments:

1Cor. 10:14

Therefore, my dear friends, flee from the worship of idols. 15 I speak as to sensible people; judge for yourselves what I say. 16 The cup of blessing that we bless, is it not a sharing in the blood of Christ? The bread that we break, is it not a sharing in the body of Christ? 17 Because there is one bread, we who are many are one body, for we all partake of the one bread.

1Cor. 11:23

For I received from the Lord what I also handed on to you, that the Lord Jesus on the night when he was betrayed took a loaf of bread, 24 and when he had given thanks, he broke it and said, “This is my body that is for you. Do this in remembrance of me.” 25 In the same way he took the cup also, after supper, saying, “This cup is the new covenant in my blood. Do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of me.” 26 For as often as you eat this bread and drink the cup, you proclaim the Lord’s death until he comes.

3. Christ with us in Prayer:

Rom. 8:26

Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we ought, but that very Spirit intercedes with sighs too deep for words. 27 And God, who searches the heart, knows what is the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints according to the will of God.

Rom. 8:31

What then are we to say about these things? If God is for us, who is against us? **32** He who did not withhold his own Son, but gave him up for all of us, will he not with him also give us everything else? **33** Who will bring any charge against God's elect? It is God who justifies. **34** Who is to condemn? It is Christ Jesus, who died, yes, who was raised, who is at the right hand of God, who indeed intercedes for us. **35** Who will separate us from the love of Christ?

... this process completed the what Christ promised in John 15:15...

John 15:15

I do not call you servants any longer, because the servant does not know what the master is doing; but I have called you friends, because I have made known to you everything that I have heard from my Father.

The church was established on the rock of the apostles confessing what the spirit revealed. (Mt. 16:15-18)

POINT: According to Jesus as then reflected in the NC revelation by the apostles... what we have now is nothing short of a complete, sufficient and thoroughly powerful presence of Jesus from God, that we might continue to have fellowship with Him...

Christianity is and always will be Personal! Everything else is good only to the degree that it serves us in abiding in Christ!

It opens the door for the continued work of the HS to give us an ever renewing, always developing personal relationship with Christ!

eg. By the endwelling spirit of God as through the means of grace given to the church, both jointly when we join together in corporate worship on Sundays, , but also severally as we meet together in homes, families, small groups, encounters, etc. etc—we are given the great privilege of abiding in Christ!

Summary: So Jesus says, "abide in me and I in you"

What this means is that Jesus has in fact come by the Holy Spirit who acts through the fellowship of the believers and the three means of grace, word, sacrament and prayer... To abide in Christ then means that we keep ourselves in Christ by means of keeping ourselves in fellowship, word, sacrament and prayer!

WE do this formally and corporately, but also in smaller groups, households and individually even...

Notice for instance Col. 3 as to what it means to live as a Christian!

16 Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly; teach and admonish one another in all wisdom; and with gratitude in your hearts sing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs to God.

17 And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him.

Conclusion: in no uncertain terms—true Spirituality is not a movement that remembers Jesus, but a living relationship with the person Jesus... take away the person Jesus, you are left with organizations, meetings, and then some more

meetings, yet another “cause” ...you have nothing that is in itself worth having... and if you are like myself, you will be tempted to become a Buddhist before it is all over!

To further illustrate and drive home this crucial point,— Jesus tells the parable of a garden.

II. Illustration of the Vine and its related lessons concerning true spirituality as a Christian:

A. The Parable of the Vine and Gardener

Vs. 1-2 **I am the true vine**, my father is the farmer. All/every branch in me that doesn't bear fruit he will take it up, even as every branch that does he will prune in order to will be pruned in order to bear more/much fruit....

There is here a comparison between the Christian life and a plant...

- Vine represents Jesus
- God the father is the gardener
- Fruitful Branches are the believers, the unfruitful branches are the unbelievers (note the significance of this—we can't separate works from true faith, even if they are distinguishable—more next week)
- The Father prunes back the good branches (believers) so that they will produce even more fruit (discipline in the fullest sense of the word to include teaching./instruction, correction, censures of the church, etc) The branches that are attached to the vine (unbelieving/Isreal in the R/H context) but do not receive any of the life of the vine are dead and are cut off and burned...

Point that I want to highly today is this: Jesus teaches his listeners that they must be vitally united to him to produce life and fruit... and that despite the trauma of suffering./discipline, his life in them shall not fail to produce a fruitful result in their lives—as most especially defined out of the principle of sacrificial love after the pattern of Christ's love for us.

Just as the branches receive the vital sap of life from the trunk as drawn from the roots, so too, any branch that is severed from the trunk will wither and die...

Calvin: The general meaning of this comparison is, that we are, by nature, barren and dry, except in so far as we have been engrafted into Christ, and draw from him a power which is new, and which does not proceed from ourselves.... that the vital sap — that is, all life and strength — proceeds from himself alone. Hence it follows, that the nature of man is unfruitful and destitute of everything good; because no man has the nature of a *vine*, till he be implanted in him. But this is given to the elect alone by special grace. So then, the Father is the first Author of all blessings, who plants us with his hand; but the commencement of life is in Christ, since we begin to take root in him.

Illustration: A Modern Gardener...

Application:

In the words of St. Augustine's prayer, "You have made us for yourself, and our hearts are restless until they rest in you."

True Christian Spirituality, historically called the gospel (or "good news"), is discovered only when we are found resting in, abiding in, being united with Jesus Christ, even as this alone is life and will bear the fruit of genuine and authentic love for God and one another!

Here is the essence of true Christian spirituality—it is not a power from within that sustains us and saves us, but that our salvation, our power, our fruits and good works are predicated upon being engrafted into Christ, being "in Christ." Notice, not in this or that tradition, this or that meeting, this or that POM, style of worship.. but in Christ!!!!

To forget this and to negate this in all that we do and all that we plan is to eventually lead down the path of, well, abandoning it all and becoming a new-age Buddhist spiritualist... but then, it would not be grafted to the vital sap that I need to live eternally!

Inferences:

- 1) We should more treasure the Holy Spirit's ministry in our midst, even as this is accomplished by the Fellowship of believers in Love, The word, Sacraments and prayer!!!!!! E.g. we should re-evaluate our involvement in these things...

We are crazy not to long for fellowship—albeit through a small group, family worship, etc, Christian meals, etc...

J.I. Packer defines fellowship this way, even as this will be the defining measure of our plan to see this happen in authentic ways in our church this year through small groups:

Fellowship is vital for our spiritual health and central to the church's true life. It is two dimensional, and it is vertical before it can be horizontal. That is we must know the reality of fellowship with the Father and his Son Jesus Christ before we can know the reality of fellowship with each other in our common relationship to God. Christian fellowship is seeking to share with others what God has made known of him to you, while letting them share with you what they know of him as a means of finding strength, refreshment and instruction for one's own soul. Gratefully one receives what others share. Equally, one labors to give. And in the giving, no less than in the taking, one finds renewal and strength. Fellowship is an expression of both love and humility. It springs from a desire to bring benefit to others coupled with a sense of personal weakness and need. It has a double motive: the wish to help and the wish to be helped, the wish to edify and the wish to be edified. It is thus a corporate seeking by Christian people to know God better through sharing with each other what individually they have learned already.

And yet, as we participate in the means of grace (fellowship, word, sacrament and prayer) WE NEED ALWAYS TO BE CAREFUL THAT WE DON'T LOOSE THE ESSENCE OF THEM AS RELATED TO OUR ABIDING IN CHRIST...

THIS passage ought also to challenge our religion!

How many ways do we expect things from our religion more than Christ!

Consider—why do we come to worship today—it should be enough if this worship, through word, sacrament and prayers, enables us in the power of the HS to encounter Christ...

Word, sacrament, prayer, are elevated in their importance, not because it might make the world a better place, but because they are the conduits by which we abide in Christ by the mediating presence of Christ through the HS.
but honestly, it is rarely all we want...

Any means that will therefore enable us to do this is something worth doing, not for what it might produce in the world necessarily, but for the intrinsic values of abiding in Christ.

Think about it—the essence of Christianity is abiding, staying, being in Christ by faith alone!

Even as Christianity will and ought to impact social justice, this isn't the essence of Christianity...
Even as Christianity will and ought to impact POM, church and mission strategies, codes for living, etc... this isn't the essence of Christianity...

Evangelicalism believed it, too, had to justify itself by pointing to what it produced. The practical outcomes pointed to by evangelicalism to show its utility and relevance originally were not so different from those of liberalism. Today the main difference is that evangelicalism in the main seeks conservative societal and political outcomes while liberalism has fallen off the edge of the lunatic fringe on these matters. But both evangelicalism and liberalism share the same "practical" and "this-worldly" orientation.

William H. Smith

Christianity, true spirituality, being a Christian, is about knowing, experiencing, living Christ, even as this will bear the fruit of genuine love...

Let me put it this way:

If your Christianity produces all sorts of holiness codes but is without love, it is not Christianity but yet another ethical system

If your Christianity separates you from the world, but it is without compassion and longing for the world to know Christ, your Christianity is but another cult.

If your Christianity inspires great organizational structures in your church, family or otherwise, as ingenious your planning may be, but these organizations do not ooze the sap of the gospel as related to knowing Christ and the forgiveness of sins and life eternal, then the organizations are but another beurocracy!

You see, Christianity is NOT ULTIMATELY ABOUT WHAT IT PRODUCES, BUT WHAT IT IS IN CHRIST... EVEN AS CHRIST WILL PRODUCE IN US GENUINE LOVE!

AGAIN,

If your Christianity gives you a mate-matching service, and later a romantic marriage and great sex life, but it fails to enable you to do good for your spouse in love even as you experience God's good for you through Christ, it is mere pagan romanticism...

IF your Christianity can help you lose weight and obtain optimum health, but is without spiritual rebirth by faith in Christ, it is naturalism.

If your Christianity gives you the chills and thrills of a rock concert but fails to give you the true Christ through the true word, sacraments and prayer, it is yet another fleeting

pleasure that will not satisfy your restless soul, but merely starve it even as it grows increasingly restless for another thrill...

If your Christianity should get Christ back in Christmas, God back in the public schools, but fail to get Christ in you such as to transform you from the inside out, it is nothing more than a political movement...

If your Christianity should make you more successful in work, secure your finances, but fail to make you more giving, more sacrificial, and more critical of selfish individualism as satisfied by your work, then it is nothing more than a self-help movement.

And it's all nauseating!

Yes, I am tired of "Christianity"—where Christ is lost together with the grace of the gospel for sinners, but organizations, meetings, movements and thrills abound...

But what is Christianity supposed to do? Two principal things: Worship God, transform sinners as sinners get into heaven—this as by abiding in Christ!

"One of the great and destructive myths of today is that worship is supposed to have a product other than worship. For many worship is like a sales meeting where the most God-centered thing that happens is that Christians get motivated to "go out there and win one for God." Worship should seem as seamless as possible with ordinary experience so that you feel as comfortable as possible. You should find, as one slogan put it, that the church is "making the good life better."

But in worship we come by a living way, Jesus Christ, into the Holy of Holies where God, 'the Judge of all men' and "a consuming fire," dwells. As we worship we are united with the "innumerable angels in festal gathering," "the assembly, of the firstborn who are enrolled in heaven," and "the spirits of the righteous made perfect" (see Heb. 12:22-29). Worship is an awesome and other-worldly event and experience. The first thing in worship is that God is worshiped. A new member of our church told me recently of being asked, "What did you learn in worship?" He replied that he was not sure he had learned a thing. But (and this is my inference) he worshiped!"

William Smith

2) We should re-evaluate our loves even as what we love reflects what we turn to to find fulfillment and life..

e.g. Even as Christ is the trunk./vine—we are the branches, and

AGAIN, "we are, by nature, barren and dry, except in so far as we have been engrafted into Christ, and draw from him a power which is new, and which does not proceed from ourselves...." Calvin

AND YET WE LOOK FOR LIFE IN ALL THE WRONG PLACES!

2Tim warns of the ways we seek life in all the wrong places...

2Tim. 3:1

You must understand this, that in the last days distressing times will come. **2** For people will be lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boasters, arrogant, abusive, disobedient to their parents, ungrateful, unholy, **3** inhuman, implacable, slanderers, profligates, brutes,

haters of good, 4 treacherous, reckless, swollen with conceit, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God,

Notice then the three things we are to avoid in essence, which are perhaps the three things that most characterize our lives...

Selfish Individualism
Hedonism
Materialism

Interesting—as Paul sees the “distress” that is caused by these things—even as we think they will bring us happiness and life!

And paul goes on to say that we will do this even while

5 *holding to the outward form of godliness* but denying its power. Avoid them!

This pretty much sums up the so called “post-modern” world and sadly, US!

Isn’t it interesting—some will avoid these three things by “holding for a form of godliness”

E.g. Holiness codes that have to do with what we eat and drink, the words we use or don’t use, styles of music in worship, this or that tradition as sacred... holding to these, even while being lovers of self, money and pleasure rather than god...

So then,

- **Holding to a form of godliness** while all the while protecting their individual freedoms and liberties by not committing themselves to anything or one... “freedom” is perhaps the # one core value of most Americans today—freedom to do what one wants, say what one wants, live how one wants, spend time as one wants—scores of social research has shown that if American’s can be identified by one single virtue, it is their commitment to individualism... wherein then social commitments are disparaged—making it harder and harder to find people that will sign on any dotted line... etc.

(see Robert bellah’, Habits of the Heart)

our society suffers from a core value that is almost total individualistic... seeking first is own personal peace and affluence...

Example: college freshman orientation—briefing on tolerance which then leads to a challenge to discover ones own self—this as applied then to sexual orientation right along side of major, and career path... instead of a course in ethics more and more colleges require a course on pluralism which then undermines any notion of absolute values

- **Holding to a form of godliness..** and all the while sinking more and more money into our homes, cloths and cars... rather than finding creative ways that we can sink more and more money into the ministry of the gospel and the things of God... as their joy increases...

Books like "Think and Grow Rich (Hill 1960) are classic of our age just because they reflect in rather crass terms, the guiding wisdom of our age as rooted in "lovers of money."

It is honestly sickening how blinded we can be on this one—"sacrificial giving" is something in the single digit percentages when compared to compared to what we spend on what most in the world would call frivolous is

It would be an interesting experiment—over the course of the last 10 years—to see what I have been willing to give to Jesus directly as compared to what I gave to myself and my family(which of course is an extension of myself)—not relative to food and basic clothing and basic homes—but as compared only to that which I spent on just upgrading what I already had which was in all likelihood sufficient... e.g. materialism..

Can money buy happiness? UC Berkeley researchers find surprising answers

By Carol Hyman, Media Relations | 16 June 2003

Psychology PhD candidate Ariel Malka and Haas School of Business professor Jennifer Chatman conducted a study using a sample of 124 UC Berkeley MBA graduates five years after graduation...

"In a capitalistic society, people generally believe that - all other things being equal - being rich is better," Chatman added. "But that is not what we found."

further up the income ladder, at the levels where basic needs are satisfied, the effect of income on well-being diminishes," he continued. "It is at these higher income levels that we expect higher order psychological needs - such as those represented by intrinsic orientation- to have implications for how income affects happiness."

"This research was conducted with a relatively high income sample - mostly white individuals who attended a top-tier MBA program," Malka said. "We would not expect income to have a negative relationship with well-being for any type of person, regardless of their values, within a lower income sample."

www.berkeley.edu/news/media/releases/2003/06/16_money.shtml

- **Holding to a form of godliness and all the while** dreaming and planning more and more how we can go to this and that exotic place, have this or that thrilling adventure, doing this or that plaything... rather than creatively thinking about how we can use our time and energy to plan more strategic ways we can serve God with our gifts, trusting that true life, joy and purpose comes is a gift of God!

(the happiest people I know are people who are invested in creative and sacrificial ways in the kingdom of God—their marriages are generally better, their joy is deeper... etc.

We should consider: Why are we so individualistic, materialistic and hedonistic—it is ultimately because we really don't believe that Christ is enough... that in Christ and abiding him as by our giving ourselves to loving his interests is found the vital sap of a thriving life and lifestyle!

Therefore,—we need to consider this passage in light of our lifestyle and core values!! We need to re-evaluate our lives—its never too late! And we need to make changes in family plans, in ambitions, in what we do with our time, money and abilities.

ABIDE IN ME, AND I IN YOU...

But where is he that we might know him...

He is here, in the fellowship of believers, in word, in prayers and yes, all of this as integrated with his *koinania* table...

LORD'S SUPPER

Readings:

1Cor. 1:30

[God] He is the source of your life in Christ Jesus, who became for us wisdom from God, and righteousness and sanctification and redemption,

John 6'' I am the bread of life..."